reckless content ‘just because something is going to give you views, going to give engagement … Once you open that door there’s no going back, because you always have to go further … Flat Earthers, anti-vaxxers, conspiracy theories in politics. It’s the same phenomenon. You see it everywhere.’[8]

Of course, the YouTube algorithms were not themselves responsible for inventing lies and conspiracy theories or for creating extremist content. At least in 2017–18, those things were done by humans. The algorithms were responsible, however, for incentivising humans to behave in such ways and for pushing the resulting content in order to maximise user engagement. Fisher documented numerous far-right activists who first became interested in extremist politics after watching videos that the YouTube algorithm *auto-played* for them. One far-right activist in Niterói told Fisher that he was never interested in politics of any kind, until one day the YouTube algorithm auto-played for him a video on politics by Kataguiri. ‘Before that,’ he explained, ‘I didn’t have an ideological, political background.’ He credited the algorithm with providing ‘my political education’. Talking about how other people joined the movement, he said, ‘It was like that with everyone … Most of the people here came from YouTube and social media.’[9]

BLAME THE HUMANS

We have reached a turning point in history in which major historical processes are partly caused by the decisions of non-human intelligence. It is this that makes the fallibility of the computer network so dangerous. Computer errors become potentially catastrophic only when computers become historical agents. We have already made this argument in chapter 6, when we briefly examined Facebook’s role in instigating the anti-Rohingya ethnic-cleansing campaign. As noted in that context, however, many people – including some of the managers and engineers of Facebook, YouTube and the other tech giants – object to this argument. Since it is one of the central points of the entire book, it is best to delve deeper into the matter and examine more carefully the objections to it.

The people who manage Facebook, YouTube, TikTok and other platforms routinely try to excuse themselves by shifting the blame from their